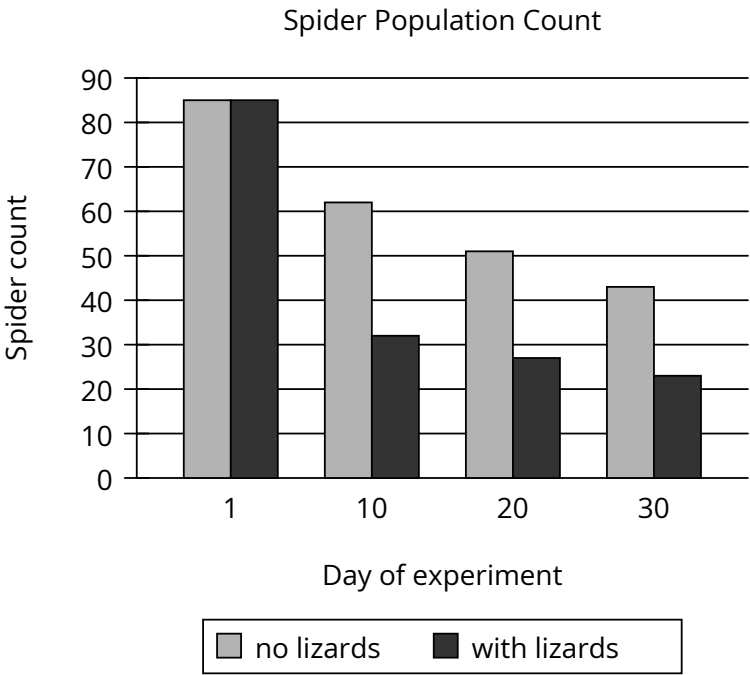


Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	Medium

Question



To investigate the effect of lizard predation on spider populations, a student in a biology class placed spiders in two enclosures, one with lizards and one without, and tracked the number of spiders in the enclosures for 30 days. The student concluded that the reduction in the spider population count in the enclosure with lizards by day 30 was entirely attributable to the presence of the lizards.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that weaken the student’s conclusion?

- Answer**
- A. The spider population count was the same in both enclosures on day 1.
 - B. The spider population count also substantially declined by day 30 in the enclosure without lizards.
 - C. The largest decline in spider population count in the enclosure with lizards occurred from day 1 to day 10.
 - D. The spider population count on day 30 was lower in the enclosure with lizards than in the enclosure without lizards.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it describes data from the graph that weaken the student’s conclusion about the reduction in the spider population in the enclosure with lizards. The graph shows that the enclosure with lizards and the enclosure without lizards each began with about 85 spiders, and that the number of spiders in each enclosure fell over the 30 days of the study. The student’s claim is that the reduction in spiders in the enclosure with lizards is “entirely attributable to the presence of the lizards,” meaning that the spider population wouldn’t have declined except for the presence of the lizards. This claim is weakened, however, by the fact that the enclosure without lizards also saw a substantial reduction in the number of spiders. Since the number of spiders fell in the enclosure without lizards as well as in the enclosure with lizards, there must be some other factor than just the presence of the lizards that contributed to the reduction in the spider population.